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Wycliffe Gordon

Wycliffe Gordon was born in 1967 in Waynesboro, Georgia. He grew up in a musical household and took up the trombone at age twelve. Wycliffe has performed with an impressive array of jazz artists to date, including Al Grey, Lionel Hampton, Shirley Horn and Wynton Marsalis. His most recent composing effort is the score for the silent film "Body and Soul."

Wycliffe was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 17, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Clearwater Beach, my name is Monk Rowe and we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Wycliffe Gordon with me this evening. I enjoyed your set last night with Joe Wilder.

WG: We had a great time.

MR: Yeah. You got some nice ovations from the crowd, I think they appreciated what you were doing.

WG: Well this is my first March.

MR: March of Jazz, an Arbors thing, yeah.

WG: March of Jazz. This is the first time I've been here and I got a chance to see some of my folks from home in Augusta, Georgia. They've been coming for quite some time, they were telling me about six or seven years ago. "You need to do the March of Jazz." I said "I'd like to." And I just got invited this year.

MR: That's great.

WG: I'm enjoying myself.

MR: Nice to get set up knowing that it's a nice event. And it's really great to see the generation thing up there. You know? You playing next to Joe Wilder and watching his reaction to what you play. I love that.

WG: Oh yeah?

MR: Yeah. It was good.

WG: I had my eyes closed, I hope it was a good one.

MR: It was. What's it like to fit in in a band that obviously is not rehearsed? Do you feel comfortable with having the repertoire under your belt for these kinds of things?

WG: Well that always helps. It always helps to be familiar with a wide range of the jazz repertoire. And you never know, you're kind of taken out of your comfort zone when you're at a jazz party and they throw a bunch of different guys together and say okay we're going to try this. Because you find comfort when you play with the same guys all the time, you know what they're going to do, they know how to interact with what it is

that you're going play, and then they say okay. So it's a bunch of guys that you might have played with here, there, maybe a jam session. But all in all I think that it's a good thing, it's a good experience. It keeps you on your toes. And playing with Joe Wilder, you know, he's played with all the greats. And last night he would call tunes, and I knew most of them but there were a couple of tunes that he was calling that not everyone was familiar with. And it was like — uh — and you know, well there's the experience. And the experience always—

MR: I know, I'm just amazed at the tunes those guys have in their heads and it's a huge part of the business I guess, especially at these things.

WG: Ah yes.

MR: Yeah. What turned you on to music? Was it the stuff in your household that was going on?

WG: Pretty much. My father was a musician. And he studied classical music. He was never really into jazz. He came into jazz in the latter part of his life with the few successes that I had, that I was having, because he would be able to turn on the radio from a small town in Waynesboro, in Georgia, called Waynesboro, Georgia, and he could get the public radio station and they'd be playing jazz. And whenever they'd say my name on the radio he said that's my son. So he started to listen to jazz. But he was a great lover of classical music. He loved Chopin, he loved, you know, Beethoven, Bach, Mozart and all of that. And when we were growing up we would hear that in the house. He had a reel to reel tape recorder that he kept on his piano and he wired speakers through the house in all the bedrooms and classical music was playing all the time. And then you know there was also the experience of going to church. Because he played in several churches in Waynesboro.

MR: As an organist?

WG: He was an organist, but he mainly played piano. Mainly played piano. And I remember him trying to get us to take piano at an early age. And it was really hard to sit at the piano for one-two-three, doing exercises and right outside of the window you could hear loud and clear the boys playing football and shooting marbles. It was like oh I don't want to do this. And he didn't make us do it, but we were offered to have music lessons because he also taught. But I took piano later on, I think when I was eleven I started playing trombone when I was twelve. And by the time I turned thirteen I got a chance to hear jazz for the first time on record. And that was a five record collection set of jazz, I think it was "Anthology of Jazz" put together by SONY or Columbia, whatever the record company was. And it belonged to a great aunt of mine that had just passed, and of the things bequeathed to the family was that. And it wound up at our house. She lived in Boston and we were in Georgia. And I used to go in the garage and put the record on, and it had

everything from slave chants up into modern jazz and what they called modern jazz at that time, was up to the Dizzy Gillespie Big Band. And there was "Sonnymoon for Two" by Sonny Rollins, but of everything that I listened to I really loved the side that had the New Orleans jazz on it. I mean it had ragtime, it just had ten different idioms of jazz if you would. And I listened to the "Keyhole Blues," by Louis Armstrong, and I was in my second, going into my third year playing trombone maybe. And so I began to try to imitate the instruments. And Louis Armstrong sang and I would always just listen to that. At that time we were into the popular music of the day, I think the popular rock group was Kiss, the popular R&B groups were like Rick James or Parliment Funkadellic, Kool and the Gang. So we were into listening to that at the time and I tried to play those things. But when I was by myself I'd always go into the garage and I'd play that record. And so that was pretty much my introduction to jazz. I think my father introduced us to music. But that was my introduction to jazz music.

MR: Yeah. I have to chuckle because you know most of the fellas I've talked to are considerably older. For you to say the popular music of the day is Kiss — it's something different you know. That's very interesting though. Your friends at the time probably did not share your growing enthusiasm for jazz music?

WG: Well they did, we had what was called a jazz band, our stage band. But the thing was we weren't playing the music of Duke Ellington, Count Basie or Benny Goodman, Fletcher Henderson, we were playing stage band instrumental, the instrumental music of popular tunes, like "Beat It" or "Billy Jean" by Michael Jackson. Every now and then a piece of Duke Ellington's music would wind up in their book but we didn't really, we weren't really into it. So I mean we called it jazz because it was instrumental music without words, and we played some of the classics like we played "In the Mood," we played "Moonlight Serenade," we played a couple of others [scats] Duke Ellington "Satin Doll." Things like that. But for the other students or friends of mine it pretty much stopped right there. We tried to improvise but my love for jazz I think just continued to grow I guess particularly after this concert that I did when I was in the eighth grade. It was the last year that they were having junior high school, which was seventh and eighth grade in the school system and then there in Georgia, switched to middle schools, and so instead of just a tenth grade class going to high school we had two classes, there was a ninth grade and a tenth grade class that would be going to high school. So a lot of the high school students came to hear the concert and they enjoyed it. There was not a lot of musicians that knew too much about improvisation, let alone how to develop that skill, in my experience anyway. But me and this one other guy, a trumpet player named Brian, said we're not going to play the written solo, we're going to just make our solo up. We're going to improvise. And the feeling that I got from that, I was thirteen then, the response

that I got from the crowd was a lot of the high school students coming to see the students from their feeder school that were going to come, they said we're getting two classes of musicians, let's see what's going to be coming to the high school. They enjoyed it, they clapped and I said oh, this is a great feeling. I said I think I want to be a jazz musician one day. And you know I went through a thing where I wanted to be a boxer, I wanted to be a truck driver, I wanted to play football, but of all of those desires, nothing really stuck like music. And then doing an interview about five or six years ago someone asked the question, "Was this something that you always knew that you wanted to do?" And I thought about it and I said, "When I was thirteen and I remember that concert," and I said, "I asked for this." I said, "I wanted to be a jazz musician and lo and behold I'm doing it professionally now." So I always say be careful what you ask for.

MR: Yeah, but it's worked out pretty good so far.

WG: It has. It's been great.

MR: Yeah. I've seen you on numerous programs and you've been pretty well recorded so far. Your meeting with Wynton was pretty fortuitous.

WG: It was. I remember the day that I met him was in February of 1987. And someone said Wynton Marsalis is going to come by the school. And all the guys that were really into jazz, and it wasn't very many but everyone knew who Wynton Marsalis was because I believe at that time he had won Grammys in classical and jazz music. And it was like man, Wynton's coming to the school. Wynton's coming. I was like okay, whatever. I mean not that — I had heard about him but I was into listening to Louis Armstrong. I said well this is a young cat, he can't possibly be playing this, I was like Wynton Schmitten. And I got to chance to meet him. He was a nice guy, very down to earth, just a cool person, a great person to hang with. And then after I began to work with him a couple of years later he remained the same, just a great person, he was a great teacher, he was never really — a lot of people used to ask is he like a work horse? Does he make you practice? No. He never says anything about practicing. You know you get on the bandstand and you hear him play and when he does his thing it's like okay [scats], back to the basics. I mean and my experience in that band was one of, it was a great growth period for me because everyone wanted to be better. They were always striving to be better. We were always talking about what they could do to make their solos and their presentation better. And we talked about it all the time. And I haven't really had that experience since. But it was a great growing situation for me.

MR: Is there a difference in your opinion of how young jazz players make their mark in today's music than twenty-five years ago?

WG: How they make their mark.

MR: Well let me put it this way. Some people have said that the young musicians get their own bands a lot sooner than some of the fellas like Sweets Edison and Al Grey and all those guys. Does that seem to be true in your case?

WG: In our generation I think that does happen. In my case I think that I waited a little while, I played with Wynton for almost, since '89, eleven, going on twelve years and I've had an association with him, I still do. But in terms of acting as a leader there was a time someone had come to me, heard me on a couple of gigs with Wynton and said, "You know you should record a record." And at that time I felt that I was still in a period or in a stage in my growth where I just wasn't ready to do that. It was like a choice between leave the band and start a solo career or stay in the band and continue to develop at the pace. And once I kind of fit — because the first year and a half, almost two years I was in the band I didn't get a chance to play a lot because I was the seventh member to join the septet and there was not a lot of music written. And then I had to get my stuff together because when I met Wynton, when I was in college, it was kind of like big fish in a small pond. And then when I got a chance to hear them play it was like oh — this is what's happening, you know a cast of better playing. I wasn't exposed to what was going on on the jazz scene. I heard about it but I got a chance to hear it firsthand with one of the most influential young musicians. And so when I was offered that opportunity I said oh, this is great, but I said I can break away now and attempt it, but I just felt that what was happening with me then, it was a much greater thing for me. But as a whole I believe that in our generation a lot of the guys are starting bands earlier, whereas in the generations that included Sweets Edison, folks like Al Grey and those musicians of that caliber, I think it was great to be a part of a great band or a great situation where you were in the band with all those great musicians. And they had great leaders. And it's hard to — in any era really — to keep a band together for several reasons. A reason can be money. A reason can be mainly you have guys that become great players, great individual players. And they want to be band leaders. All the great players are not necessarily great band leaders, but the thing is if everyone was to become a great player then you never really would have a band. A band like the John Coltrane Quartet, you know they stayed together. Even Miles, he went through several bands but guys, you think about someone like Harry Carney that stayed with Duke forty years, his whole professional music career was with Duke Ellington's band. And I guess he felt, as I did for a great period of time, that I was with Wynton Marsalis. This is a great musical situation.

MR: Yeah. This is where I belong.

WG: The growth that takes place, I can go out and become a solo musician and try to become a star but you know musically you just have to ask yourself sometimes, what are you going to be, what is going to give you the greatest gratification? The money that you're going to

make as a leader? The prestige of being a leader? Or what you're going to gain musically when you take, which is I guess the emphasis behind these jazz parties, get a bunch of great guys together and play even if it's just for thirty minutes.

MR: Yeah.

WG: And so I think the answer to your question is yes, my generation guys are a lot quicker to become leaders. And you know I used to hear that even from my high school band director. Oh it's great that you're playing with Wynton Marsalis, but I meant for you to go and do your own band. And it's kind of hard, because when you have a great band together it's like good, so now you have a great band with great players — not saying that I was a great player but I mean I'll certainly say the other guys — well what if everyone said oh, well I want to have my band, I want to have my band, I want to have my band. And then if you have a continuous cycle of you have your band together for five years and then the guys in your band become great players. No one would ever really have a band. And I think the strength of a lot of the organizations, even when it was with the big bands, was that they had great players that just stayed in the band. You know they did a couple of solo projects on the side, but what made those bands great, they had great players in the band. Think of those great big bands. They weren't great because the leaders were great. They were great because it was the team effort. So I do think that that happens a little more in our generation. We're really quick to — because the pressures of that kind of thing. The entrepreneurial spirit. And I think that it's good but I also think it's also good to understand the importance of having a great unit and guys staying together for that purpose, for the music.

MR: Right. Who were your major trombone influences?

WG: I know this doesn't answer your question, I think my greatest influence was not a trombone player, it was Louis Armstrong actually. But guys that played with him. I'm often asked the question who is my favorite. I don't really have one favorite because the trombone has many voices. And you have people like Jack Teagarden or Trummy Young, guys like Al Grey. Even guys like Frank Rosolino. A guy like Bill Watrous. I admired Bill Watrous for a long time. I got a chance to hear him when I was in high school and started to develop my playing I heard a recording of him and I was like man, okay. Trombone? And then you know I got a chance to meet him and play with him live. Who else? I mean I like guys like Vic Dickenson and Dicky Wells because of how they used the trombone. I mean you have guys that played plunger and there's so many differences between the way Al Grey plays or the way that Tricky Sam Nanton plays, all the way to Bubber Miley plays plunger, the difference between him and Cootie Williams. And they're trumpet players, but just speaking a little bit about the plunger, there are so many guys. I love Slide Hampton. I wouldn't say that he was a traditional, traditional as

is categorized with the early New Orleans style or even a Dixieland style. I love J.J. Johnson. He's great. He's one of the cleanest trombone players ever. I love Curtis Fuller. I got a chance to work with him a couple of weeks ago. There are many. Major influences? I say guys like Lawrence Brown. He played the trombone like a trombone. He didn't try to do the acrobatics of a saxophone or a trumpet. He played the trombone. He sang. He sang when he played. A lot of guys. Britt Woodman even. Some of the guys, well he's no longer with us, but Buster Cooper, the way he played trombone. He will, when he wants to, he can play pretty sweet but when he wants to man just fly, he like whip.

MR: Do they call him the bumble bee or something?

WG: I guess. But I mean and one of the great things about, I didn't get a chance to meet all of these guys, but their personalities are just so great, they're great people. Like I said Louis Armstrong is my, I would say is my, the one, if I had to choose one person that was most influential in jazz slash music to me I would have to say it was Louis Armstrong. But guys that played with him, Quentin "Butter" Jackson. I know he was another great trombone player. And he was also another one of the great plunger mute men. The guy that played vibes — I can never think of his name and he played with Pops, he played with Duke, and he was a great vibraphonist.

MR: Not Hampton?

WG: Hmmm? Not Slide. It's not Al Grey, I can't think of it. It's going to come to me in a second. Oh, Tyree Glenn. I can never think of why I always get tied up with his name, Tyree. He played with Louis Armstrong. He was a great trombonist also. And I called all of those names, I think they all influenced me because at one point I spent time studying their style of playing or a particular solo that they may have done. Like the difference between the way Al Grey plays plunger, the way Tyree plays, the way that Quentin "Butter" Jackson plays. The way that Tricky Sam Nanton plays. You have a different approach to the plunger. And I listened to all of those. Open horn, the guys that played with Louis Armstrong. With Jack Teagarden. I love Jack Teagarden. He's great. I mean he had great command and mastery of the instrument. But he played a little different from Trummy Young but I like both of their styles. Vic Dickinson and Dicky Wells. You listen to them play sometimes and you just want to start laughing. Because when they play they kind of had a human element in the — a vocal element when they played on some of the recordings that I've heard. I heard one recording of — I can't think of the name of the recording but it was a comedy show. And they were playing. And Vic Dickinson? Dicky — it was one of them. And they started off their thing like [scats] it was just like someone saying something. And it was just — I said oh man. And I'd have never thought to just do that on the horn and again, just the many different approaches. So I listened to

the way people talk from time to time. I think about the way that people laugh from time to time. So when I go to play I don't try to play the note that fit in this chord or the scale that — I try not to make it technical but more vocal, which is what I figure that the instrument is truly for.

MR: Very good for that.

WG: It should sing.

MR: That's a good talking point about what people think about when they're improvising. Are you a chordal oriented person? I mean did you have theory on the way up so that you know what all those chord changes mean?

WG: Yes. I had music theory. I did it in the classroom from a quote unquote technical point of view and then made it practical. I thought about well this chord goes, these are the notes that go with this chord, the C seven, C-E-G-B flat. And if I wanted to put the nine on it I could do this. And then I went through the stage of practicing patterns that would go with certain chords. But then, you know from listening to Louis Armstrong, the only difference between his trumpet playing and his singing was the octave. He played the trumpet an octave higher than what he sang. Other than that there was no difference. And so I began to sing. So when I'm playing I'm thinking about what I'm hearing. And I began, in my study of theory, to begin to do things rather than sit down to the piano and come up with a formula that you can write down on the paper. But I began to try to work on things that would help to develop my ear. So I would do ear training exercises like in order to truly hear the sound of a chord or a form, something like the blues, I would sing all the chords rather than just play them. I would sing them and say okay, because when you sing, and it's important to sing in tune, when you sing them then you're forced to hear, you have to hear the correct pitches. When you're playing an instrument, you go over to the piano, you hit the key, the note is going to come out. If you're playing a brass instrument you have your embouchure setting in the right mode of resonance, enough air, the right fingering and the right position, the note is going to come out. But when you sing you have to adjust the pitch. And you have to hear the pitch. So I began to do things like that. And then I would take a form like the blues and just start improvising [scats]. And I began to just sing it. So when I would pick my horn up I began to hear phrases that I would sing, rather than it being a task. Oh I'm playing the trombone I have to play these notes and in this position. I began to play the things that I was hearing that I was singing. And I think that my improvisation began to improve, at least for me as an individual, because I began to play what I was hearing rather than what I'd figured out by practicing the patterns in Person A's method book or Person B's book of transcriptions. Or things like that. And all of those things are good steps, I believe, when you're working on improvisation. Some of it jazz cats quote unquote don't like to use the Jamey Aebersold

method, I said don't knock that. I say it's always good to have live musicians but if that's all you have, then hey, deal with that. That was good for me when I was in high school, to play with the Jamey Aebersold record. Now you don't get a chance to do any interaction because no matter where you start it's not going to be good from that standpoint. But once I began to sing, you know take Louis Armstrong's approach from scatting, I think my improvisation began to improve. So when I'm playing if I don't hear something I try not to fall back on, because I did go through this stage too, I would fall back on cliched phrases, things that people would recognize like [scats] — oh yeah that's cute. But okay then as I got older I was like okay this is not so cute anymore. Let me address them. Because you know you play that for the older musicians it's like oh, you know, the guys that really want to deal with you or to play in the spirit of true improvisation. And that would happen from time to time when we were on the road in Wynton's band with the septet. Because that part we were talking about earlier about guys leaving the band early, but when you play with musicians for a long time you get to know what they like to do. You get to know their strengths. And you get to know, you know you can play something and they know what you like. They go let's try this, let's try that. And then every now and then you'll step off on a limb and you say I'm just gonna go for it. You're hearing something and you want to just play something just totally new, totally fresh. And it doesn't always work out. But just in the spirit of doing it, it can be very exhilarating. And there are those times when it does work out. That's one thing — oh I'm sorry, I'm making my answers too long.

MR: That's all right. You know in talking to the veteran musicians along the way, the older — of course you're a veteran now for sure —

WG: Oh thanks.

MR: Three or four generations ago—

WG: Okay, you made it sound as though I'm to get my benefits.

MR: Don't quit your gig.

WG: Okay I won't.

MR: It seemed to have been a considerable fraternity amongst the musicians in the jazz world, and I wonder if you feel at this point, is there a real kind of bond, a helping of each other in the community of people you work with?

WG: I think that it's happening. It's kind of hard to tell because I'm not one that — most of the time when I travel I'm in my room working on music so I don't get the chance to interact with a lot of musicians. But it's been, I think it's kind of like a catch 22. There are those of us that try to stick together and support one another in the name, in the spirit of what the older musicians would do because I feel like there was a generation of musicians where that existed. And that could have been like Sweets Edison's generations, guys like

Britt Woodman. And then came the bebop period and not that all the guys took on this, but I think that it became more of a me-thing. It became more of music for the musicians. And not that non-musicians couldn't listen to it, but I think there was a social element in the music during the Swing Era where people would get together and go listen to the music because they didn't just have to sit down and listen at a concert, they could dance with the music and it had a social element that invited everyone. And I think when the — not just when the bebop period came along because — I'll tell this story. I had some friends of mine on trombone, there's a jam session that takes place in New York the first Monday of every month at this sculpture's house, Clint Meadmore. I don't know if you know about that. But musicians just come over there and most of the time it's by invitation. I was invited by a friend of mine, David Oswald. And they play mostly traditional jazz or trad jazz as they call it. And again, most of the guys in my generation were introduced to jazz through the bebop era, whereas I started out listening to Louis Armstrong. I heard a little Sonny Rollins, I may have heard a little John Coltrane, but I usually listened to Louis Armstrong. You know, "Pennies From Heaven," that's the kind of thing that I liked. And I couldn't tell you why back then, but there was something about that, I knew that whenever I would listen to Louis Armstrong play I felt good. Whenever I'd watch, whenever I saw any video footage of him playing the people felt good and there was something about that I liked. Bebop music was very sophisticated rhythmically and harmonically but it seemed that the music had become more about the music and the music for the musicians. And not that the complete dance element was taken out of the music but a lot of it was. You know it's the difference between dancing for dances only and trying to dance to "Giant Steps." Now while "Giant Steps" is — when it comes to dealing with that technically, harmonically, I mean you are challenged with your technical proficiency in terms of playing with velocity because of the speed which the tunes goes, you are challenged by your harmonically because of the rate at which the chord changes move. This is, you know, but who wants to put that on — you want to put it on and you can listen to it and you can enjoy it, but not too many people will want to dance to that. Thelonious Monk, he was in the bebop era, he kind of kept the dance element to his music because his music pretty much dances. But I'm getting away from the —

MR: It's all right. I like this subject.

WG: I'm kind of getting away from the question. But and I think all of that, it has something to do with the way the musicians are towards one another. I think when the bebop era came in and musicians said it's about me kind of thing, as where there when you were playing music that was more communal like a big band, or when you were playing the New Orleans style or traditional or what they call Dixieland, it was all interactive. It was a

communal thing. It wasn't about I'm soloing and you know, check out what I'm doing. It was more communal. And I think the guys and ladies, the people that played that music, they were more communal in their approach to life and to each other. And our generation today, because most of the musicians grew up listening to bebop, one thing that I think I dislike is it's hard sometimes, it seems like a lot of the musicians don't really get or give props to another musician until after they're dead and gone. Some of us, I'd say a great majority of the musicians, when we see the guys we haven't seen in a while, they're very supportive. But then there's that generation of musicians that really, for one reason or another, they're not happy with the way their career went. They are not satisfied with the young lions so to speak. They're not satisfied with the way their career went and then you have young lions coming up and they're getting recognition and they were not happy for various reasons. So rather than to deal with the majesty and the music, they began to take it personally and then there's, for lack of a better term I'll say confusion, in terms of well who's supporting who. And you know all the musicians, you know jazz is not, we're not making millions and millions of dollars playing jazz. Maybe a few people are but it's not like when you go to a rock concert or to a rap concert, so why in the jazz community should we not support one another? And I think that's one of the great things about these jazz parties. And I haven't been, I'm kind of a baby to the jazz party because working with Wynton Marsalis, we were on the road almost three hundred days out of the — I wasn't available to go to a lot of them. But it's great when you have someone like Joe Wilder, I'll say this then I'll be quiet, or Britt Woodman, they were always supportive of the younger cats. And that doesn't happen — the generation between Joe Wilder, I'll say a musician between Joe Wilder and mine, they are always supportive. And even in their teaching. They weren't patronizing. They were always supportive. Always had something good to say. Always gave a word of encouragement. Sweets Edison, he was the same way. And if he didn't like something, he didn't like it. But he would never be like you need to do this, or these young guys they're not playing anything. He never really had the attitude. And there's a lot of musicians that are kind of like that. And some of them are guys in our generation. I say well what happened to the spirit of, you know, trying to play? Buster Cooper, he's another. He's always, just always, says you young guys are doing it, carrying on the tradition. And there's always, I think we need those guys to egg us on and to be supportive.

MR: I think you're right and I think that some of that comes — some of the lack of that I believes comes from this term I heard recently and that was jazz in the middle ages, that the people that are in that generation of being around 50 or so forth, some of them feel that the younger guys are getting all the marketing support and the record company support and what about me.

WG: Right. There's a lot of that. Joe Wilder doesn't take on that. He doesn't take on that attitude. Buster Cooper, he didn't take on that attitude. Britt Woodman, he didn't take on that attitude. But some of the guys that are under him, it seems like they're bitter, it's like hey man, you could not be playing jazz at all. I mean things haven't always been great. I mean just like in life, there's ups and there's downs, but you take the good with the bad and you just try to roll with it. And I think that's the spirit that those guys have. Because the time that they come up, in terms of social conditions and whatnot, they were not as great as they are now. So and I say if you have guys that grew up in that time period and they live with a certain amount of optimism, I mean how could you go wrong?

MR: You know jazz was very important in helping to break down some social barriers, racial barriers, even preceded Jackie Robinson. Where is the state of that in music now for you? From what you see anyway?

WG: I think, I guess there's elements of everything that existed before that are still — but me personally I haven't really experienced much of anything that's negative. I haven't always been happy with anything from my playing to well maybe well I didn't get this gig or it didn't work out or a promoter didn't pay me. You know, things happen. But I think it all depends on how you look at life. Do you want to be a person that's going to live and complain about your condition or whatever the conditions are or do you want to do something about them? I mean it's one thing to recognize something, you can either do something about it or I think get around it. Let's see am I answering your question? I don't think it is, we're not going in the musician's entrances or I mean there's stage entrances but I've never walked up to a water fountain that said "white only" or "colored only." I haven't seen it. But you know different places you do and it can be a small town or there's still people that live in the world that are prejudiced. I feel sorry for them. But I don't have — I haven't experienced much of that.

MR: Good. I'm glad actually. What's in the near future for you? You've got your own group on and off? Is it a thing that you have trouble keeping together or just as the opportunities present themselves?

WG: I will go with the latter. I mean just as opportunities present themselves. I haven't desired it yet that I wanted to work full time on the road with a band, the Wycliffe Gordon Quartet, Quintet, Sextet, Septet, Big Band. I don't know. Right now I'm composing a lot. I recently did a film score for a silent film that was done in '25 by Oscar Micheau, called "Body and Soul." I want to do that. What's on the burner for me? I'd like to do everything in music, whether I ever get an award for it or not doesn't matter, but I love choir music, I love Gospel music, of course I love jazz music, I love classical music. I'd like to publish a book of some of, well several books, of some of my works, even if it's for small ensembles, trombone choir, brass quintet, or I like to — and actually record the

music. So if I don't hear it — it doesn't have to be played on National Public Radio, it can just be played in my living room. But I'd like to be able to hear everything that I've written, get it out of here, on the paper, and maybe get the music performed. I think I'll always be into teaching. I'm presently teaching at Michigan State and will be involved with the new jazz program at Juilliard that's starting in the fall of 2001. I love to play and to perform but I love to write. Because a performance can last in the — if you get it recorded it can last forever, but I would like to continue to compose music for various aggregations but not just jazz, and that's what I would like to do.

MR: Where does your inspiration come from for writing new music?

WG: Oh different things. It could be life experiences. I grew up in the church down south, I was in church every Sunday whether I wanted to be or not. I'd really like to do a Gospel album. I recorded a record on Cris Cross called "The Gospel Truth," which was hymns and spirituals and a couple of original compositions. But it depends. It comes from many things. But mainly things that are blues based and the feeling I guess of the music of the church. And I think it's intertwined in many different things. And sometimes I just am walking around, I hear things and I start to sing. And I learned a very important lesson when I was in college. I write everything down now. Because if you don't, I think it's very mysterious how this music thing works in terms of new music coming to you. It was, I'll never forget it. I was playing in a symphonic band and I said I want to write a piece of symphonic or wind ensemble music. And it was just clear to me as day. And it took place over a three day period. I said oh, this is the thing. I was in college, taking a music course, and we were studying, I forget, Stravinsky or someone. And talking about theme and variations. A theme and how to develop a theme. And I said I'm going to write a piece of this music. And it was the spring season when we have concert band. And I hear the French horn part, I heard the trumpet parts, I heard all the percussion parts, and I said the first day, and the second day it was like oh yeah. And I didn't write it down because it was just clear and just fresh in my mind. And the third day I was on the bus going somewhere and I said, oh yeah, this is how I can end the piece. And I said, you know I felt like it would be a great piece of music but who knows. But the thing is on the fourth day it was gone. And it was strange. And I could remember fragments of it, where just the day before I could hear the whole piece from beginning to end. My first symphonic piece of music. And I said oh man, just wow. And then like two, maybe like two years later I was riding in the car listening to a classical radio station and a piece of music I had never heard before, I found myself singing along with it. And I said I was baffled. So I never, and one other instance where it happened, it wasn't my music but a piece of Wynton Marsalis' music. We were playing from "In This House On This Morning" and we recorded the music and it had not come out yet. And we were on a tour

somewhere on the west coast, some small rural town out in the midwest. And one of the themes that he wrote [scats] and on the radio we was listening to a jazz station, we had about twenty minutes to get to the sound check, and a guitarist comes on playing [scats]. I said okay, well the first four measures, well I was just hearing the same thing. And then he played the next, and again we hadn't recorded the music, and this was recorded because it was on the radio. And it was almost exactly identical to what Wynton had written. And we all just looked at each other in the van. I said man it's wild how this music thing happens. Because there was no correlation between the two, between Wynton and whoever this person was. And then we saw him so I said, "You're not going to believe this, this was one segment from a piece that you had written, and it was almost exactly note for note, chord change for chord change, the same thing." So I learned from my experience that when I hear some music if I don't have music paper I'll make staff and I'll just write it down, or enough of it to where I'll know when I come back to it what frame of mind I was in. And also from the experience of listening to that piece of music that was reminiscent of something that Wynton had done. I say man it's strange how things just work in the world of music, or just how music moves around. And one last quick thing, I was at a jam session with Wes Anderson in New Orleans and Wynton's band hadn't been together. He stopped in September or December of 1995. So this was like '96, '97. And they were playing a blues on the stage, Victor Goines was improvising and Wes picked up his horn and I picked up my horn at the same time and were just going to play a background. And we were coming in at the same time [scats]. And we looked at each other. Because we both heard — like we were both hearing the same thing. And Wynton used to talk about that with one of the guys that was in the band one time with Todd Williams, how sometimes we will not just wind up on the same note but end up playing the same phrase. And we'll just like look at each other and say who did that.

MR: I guess there's some musical ideas floating around out there and people tune into them at the same time.

WG: It's amazing.

MR: Just to wrap up here, did you get a chance to watch most of the Ken Burns thing?

WG: I've seen very little of it. But what I have seen I've enjoyed it. I've enjoyed it. Well I don't know if you're asking me what I think about it, but I'm getting ready to tell you.

MR: What do you think about it?

WG: I think it's great simply for this reason. It's something positive about our music that's being done, it's televised and given to the masses. Amongst the musicians there's been controversy, there's too much Wynton Marsalis on it, or they didn't cover anything after 1965 or they didn't talk about all the piano players. I say yeah if they didn't talk about

piano players, imagine what they did to the trombone. They didn't say anything about — and you know I didn't watch. I don't get a chance to watch much television so I bought the video box set and I will get a chance to watch it at my leisure. But I was out, we were doing a residency activity in Decorah, Iowa somewhere, it was a part of a grant that they had to bring Lincoln Center out to do jazz workshops and residences in rural areas. And the Ken Burns series, it was a couple of months ago, it was in February, and the Ken Burns series was on television. And the people that came to our workshop had so much more, because we were there two years prior and we were supposed to go to four small towns, twice within a three year period. That was a part of the grant program. And the people that watched the Ken Burns thing, it was on before they came to our performance that night, they had so much more of an appreciation for jazz music. Because they didn't have a jazz record store, please. Probably no jazz radio station. Nothing. But they saw that on television. And they said wow we saw the Ken Burns series and they were really excited about jazz. Not because they had to go and — it's one thing to listen to it on record, but with the video series they have the music footage and then you see the musicians talking about the music and you get a chance to watch them play live. It's a whole 'nother means, a whole 'nother level of appreciation that you can develop for it. And for that reason, and I think it was Pella, we were in Pella, Iowa, for that reason I say that it's a great series. I don't care if they didn't get all the piano players, they didn't get all the trombone players, they didn't cover everything. And my thing to all the guys that say that, whatever they didn't cover, you can get into the entrepreneurial spirit and you can do a video series and call it "The Monk Rowe Series" and I'll call it "The Wycliffe Gordon Series" and I'll cover the trombone players. But what that did for jazz was great. Because it did what we don't get a chance to do often. The people that come to these jazz parties are the people, they're hip to jazz. They know what the deal is. They want to go hear a bunch of musicians get together that haven't played together or that played together very little, and they get a chance to hear some of the music that they grew up listening to and some of the younger people were fortunate enough to have passed and played jazz music in the home. They say yeah I'm going to hear some live jazz and it's going to be spontaneous and it's going to be just like a party. So my thing is I think that the Ken Burns series is great. Because I feel like this, if he would have put everyone in the video, including myself, then there would be someone talking about well he didn't need to be in it, he didn't need to be in there, oh they did too much on this, they did too much on that. I think it was a great series and it is great for jazz.

MR: Well you're the second person just today who described the same scenario, getting in front of a group of people and all of a sudden they're more hip than they were before the thing was shown.

WG: Exactly.

MR: And so that's good.

WG: And for that reason I say A plus plus.

MR: Well listen I appreciate your spending this time with me.

WG: I enjoyed it.

MR: And I really hope for the best for your career and your composing especially. I love to hear that you're writing new music, that people are doing that out there, because it really lasts.

WG: Okay. I'll make sure that I get your card or whatever now, I'll send you some.

MR: Okay.

WG: Great.

MR: Thanks for your time.

WG: All right, appreciate it.